round to short midwicket, threw at the stumps … and I stupidly lifted my bat out of the way to let the ball through.

Dopey, but not disastrous, because of the reverse swing employed by Jimmy and Steven Finn, who had come in for the injured Stuart Broad. We needed only 41 to win; I was stumped, fourth ball, after a rush of blood, followed quickly by Trotty and KP. At 8–3, I was so nervous I literally could not watch. I sat on the toilet until Compo and Belly put me out of my misery.

We won the toss in the final Test, on a flat pitch at Nagpur, and didn't bat particularly well in occupying the crease for 145 overs, scoring just 330. It was attritional, soporific cricket, though I managed to be sufficiently alert to run out Dhoni on 99 in India's reply. Trotty and Belly scored centuries in a second innings we stretched to 154 overs, and the series was ours.

It took me a long time to appreciate the significance of that win. Playing in India is an immersive experience, since the game drives a billion people absolutely barking mad. The gods of their game, Tendulkar, Dhoni and Kohli, live surreal, detached lives. I've rarely spoken to them deeply, because they have become distant figures by the nature of their fame.

How they perform under such extraordinary pressure is incredible. When Tendulkar went out to bat, electricity surged around the ground. It felt as if the world had stopped to watch, and wait, for its portion of perfection. When he got out there was a deathly silence, as if the world had stopped turning.

Scoring a hundred hundreds under that sort of pressure is an almost unbelievable achievement. My fear of failure drove me on, but what he went through, on a daily basis for twenty-five years, was of another magnitude. No one is immune to self-doubt, but he was a prisoner of his genius. The responsibility of pleasing so many people, so often, demanded a barely credible inner strength.

We should have done the double, by winning the one-day series, but lost it 3–2. The noise in the opening match, on Dhoni's home ground in Pune, was off the scale. I was at first slip and couldn't hear James Tredwell, who was alongside me at second. It was ludicrously loud. Screeching assaulted the ears like feedback from an electric guitar held up to an amplifier.

In England, I cherish my freedom to roam as I wish. In India, leaving your hotel involves a calculated gamble. Before the final game of that one-day series, in Dharamsala, Ian Bell, Chris Woakes and I went out to a pizza